

THE PRESSURE COOKER

Lakshmi Iyer offers a frontline view of the realities women face in high-intensity finance. “Women are still in the minority across financial services. It can be tough for those early in their career,” she says. Market-linked roles involve long hours and volatile cycles. “For those on the frontline, the challenges compound, from long working hours to high-octane moments when global markets turn volatile,” she says.

Her advice to young women is simple and forceful. “Never quit. If this is your passion, pursue it, come what may. *‘Lagey raho’* has been my mantra,” says Iyer.

Her early years reveal a different challenge: the absence of structured guidance. “There was no formal mentoring when I started. I was the maker and checker of key decisions. It made the journey harder. But I never gave up,” she recalls.

OVER GENERATIONS

Radhika Gupta represents a more recent corporate era shaped by slow but steady improvement in female representation. Her explanation for the rise of women in leadership is pragmatic. “It’s the power of the pipeline,” says Gupta. As more women entered finance at the junior level over the last two decades, the cohort now reaching leadership positions is larger than ever before. She also notes that leadership itself has changed. The command-and-control culture has ceded ground to a more collaborative and empathetic model. “Women leaders foster inclusion, reduce attrition, and improve innovation,” says Gupta. These traits are increasingly valued in modern finance.

The industry’s shift towards technology and AI will sharpen this need even further. “Finance is no longer just about numbers. It’s about behaviour, trust, and sustainability,” says Gupta.

Women & Investing

1 **A total of 59 out of 540 fund managers in India are women**

2 **Organisations are becoming more collaborative, empathetic, and flexible. Women often excel in these environments**

3 **Team-based portfolio management has expanded. This broadens the funnel for talent and allows women to build visibility and responsibility without being confined to niche roles**

4 **Reports from TransUnion CIBIL and NITI Aayog show more women applying for credit, starting enterprises, and steering household finances. This will be an advantage for women finance professionals**

REDESIGNING THE SYSTEM

Madhu Lunawat entered the financial sector in 2007 and has witnessed the transformation firsthand. “Earlier, the path to leadership felt less defined for women. The priority was to prove competence in a system not built for the realities women face,” says Lunawat. “Today, the shift is profound. It is no longer about whether women belong in finance, but how we accelerate their journey.”

Yet being a woman founder comes with its own set of obstacles. “The ecosystem celebrates the idea of a woman entrepreneur but often applies a higher standard of scrutiny. The scepticism is subtle but persistent,” says Lunawat. She does not view this scepticism as discouragement. ‘*MF Didi*’ is Lunawat’s visionary programme designed to widen the base of women in financial distribution. “Women often prefer to discuss money with other women. By building this network, we are democratising wealth creation,” says Lunawat.

All women leaders agree on one point: Indian women still shoulder disproportionate household and emotional labour, which restricts bandwidth for demanding roles.

THE ROAD AHEAD

India’s investment industry stands at an inflection point. Data highlights imbalance, but the stories show momentum. Reports from TransUnion CIBIL and NITI Aayog indicate more women applying for credit, starting enterprises, and influencing household finances.

But industries do not transform based on sentiment. They change when institutions redesign them-

selves, when leaders challenge outdated norms, and when women refuse to shrink their ambition.

If India wants a resilient financial ecosystem, it will need more women not merely entering the workforce but leading it. **BT**